What is Politics?

Comparative Politics

August 31, 2021

Last time

- Focus on the **science** part of Political Science
- **Science:** Trying really hard to prove ourselves wrong
- **Today:** Focus on the **politics** part
- What makes a situation *political*?
- When is it `useful` to think of something as a political situation?

Jamboard

(again)

Michel Foucault

Michel Foucault

Discipline & Punish

The Birth of the Prison

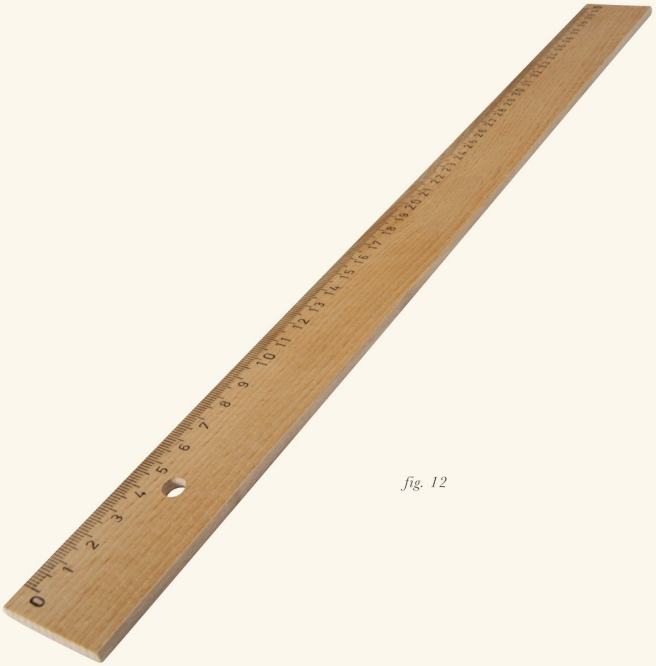


fig. 12

Definition

- **Politics:** Any relationship that involves power imbalance or struggle
- **CGG:** *"Politics comprises the subset of human behavior that involves the use of power or influence"*
- Virtually **any** human interaction or relationship is political
- That doesn't mean it's useful to think of every human behavior as such

Exit, Voice, and Loyalty (EVL)

- A **model** to understand political interactions
- Models are always wrong, but sometime useful
- Uses game theory to understand circumstances under which:
  1. Citizens will change behavior in response to a stimulus `(e.g government action)`
  2. Governments will pay attention/ignore citizen demands
- Not **exclusively** about citizens and governments, but useful for our purposes

Aside: Game Theory

- A set of mathematical tools `(models, techniques)` to understand **strategic interdependence**
- **Strategic:** Outcome depends on the actions of those involved
- **Assumption:** Actors have `complete` and `transitive` preferences. They are **rational** `(not always realistic but useful)`
- EVL is an **extensive form** game
- **Players** move in sequence, one after the other
- **Complete information:** Can anticipate the other player's reaction to their move

Types of games and equilibria

	Information	
Order	**Perfect**	**Imperfect**
Simultaneous	Nash Equilibrium	Bayesian Nash Equilibrium
Extensive	Subgame Perfect Equilibrium	Perfect Bayesian Equilibrium

- EVL is an extensive game with perfect information
- **Equilibrium:** No player has unilateral incentives to change strategy

EVL actions

- **Exit:** You accept that there has been a negative change in your environment, and you alter your behavior to achieve the best outcome possible given your new environment
- **Voice:** You use your "voice" to try to change the environment back to its original condition
- **Loyalty:** You accept the fact that your environment has changed and make no change to your preexisting behavior

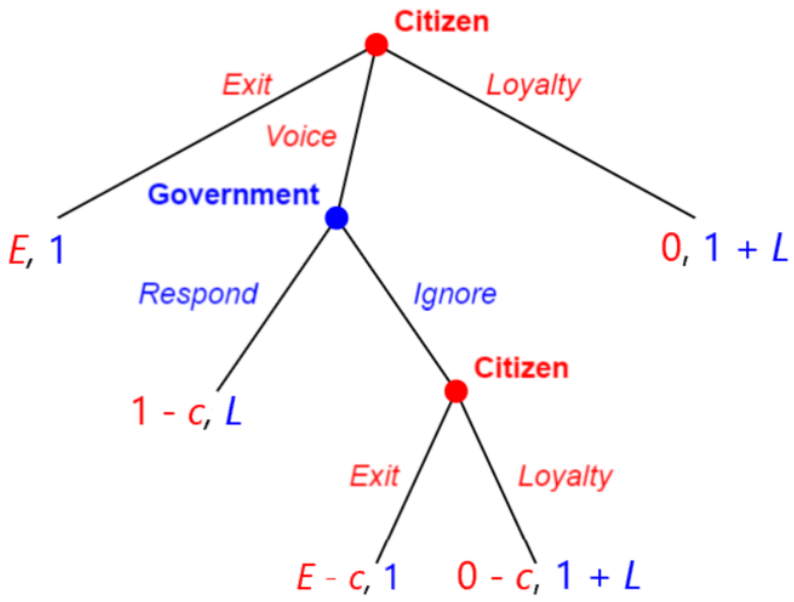
EVL sequence

- **Exogenous** change to environment
- **C:** Citizen `(Exit, Voice, Loyalty)`
- **G:** Government `(Respond, Ignore)`
- **C:** `Exit, Loyalty`

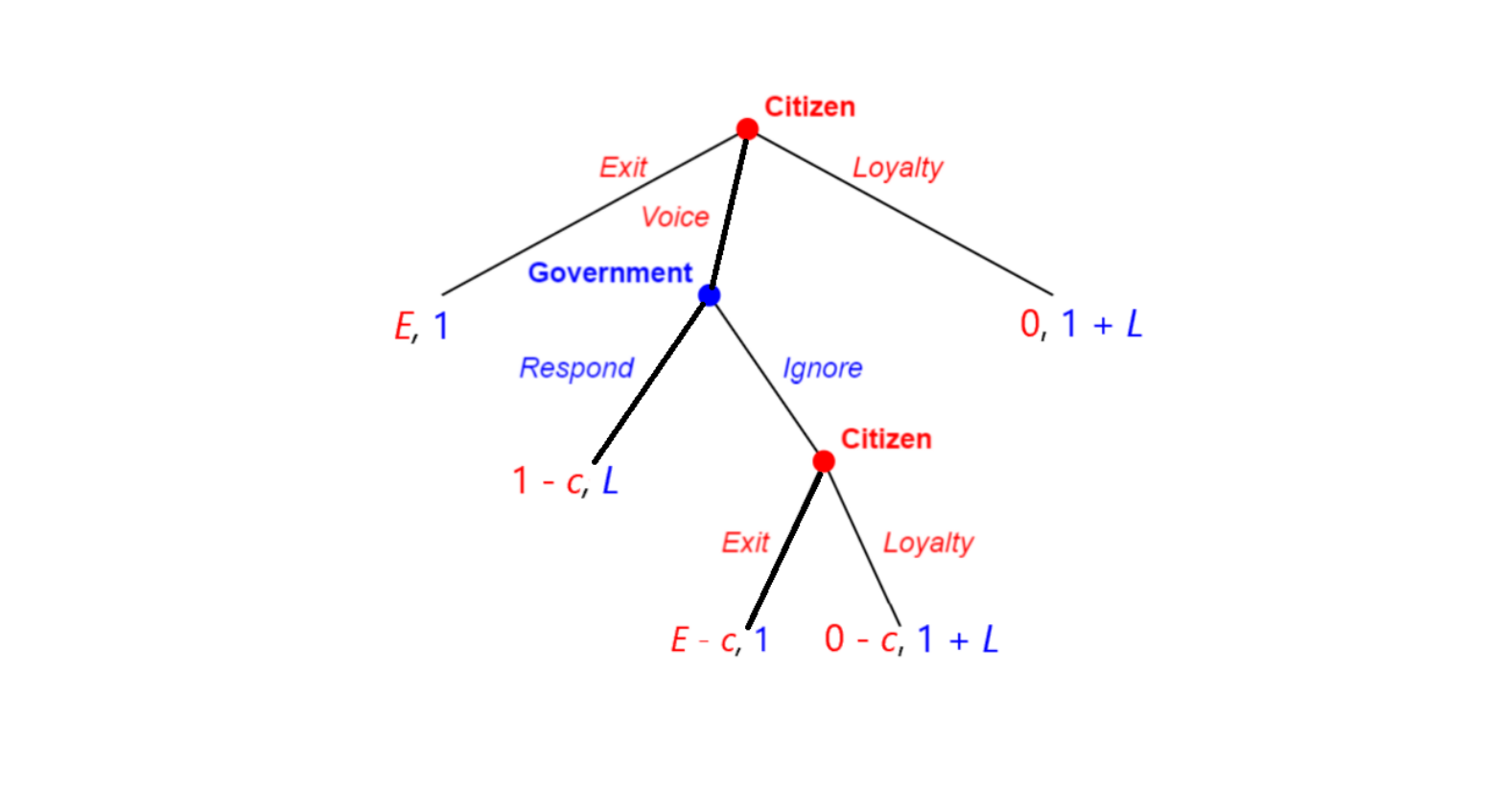
EVL setup

- **C loyalty payoff** $= 0$
- **G loyalty payoff** $= 1 + L$, $L > 0$
- **E:** Citizen payoff from taking exit option
- **c:** Cost of voice, $c > 0$
- Assume $E < 1 - c$ `(You prefer government to fix things for you)`
- **Equilibrium** depends on values of E and L

Game

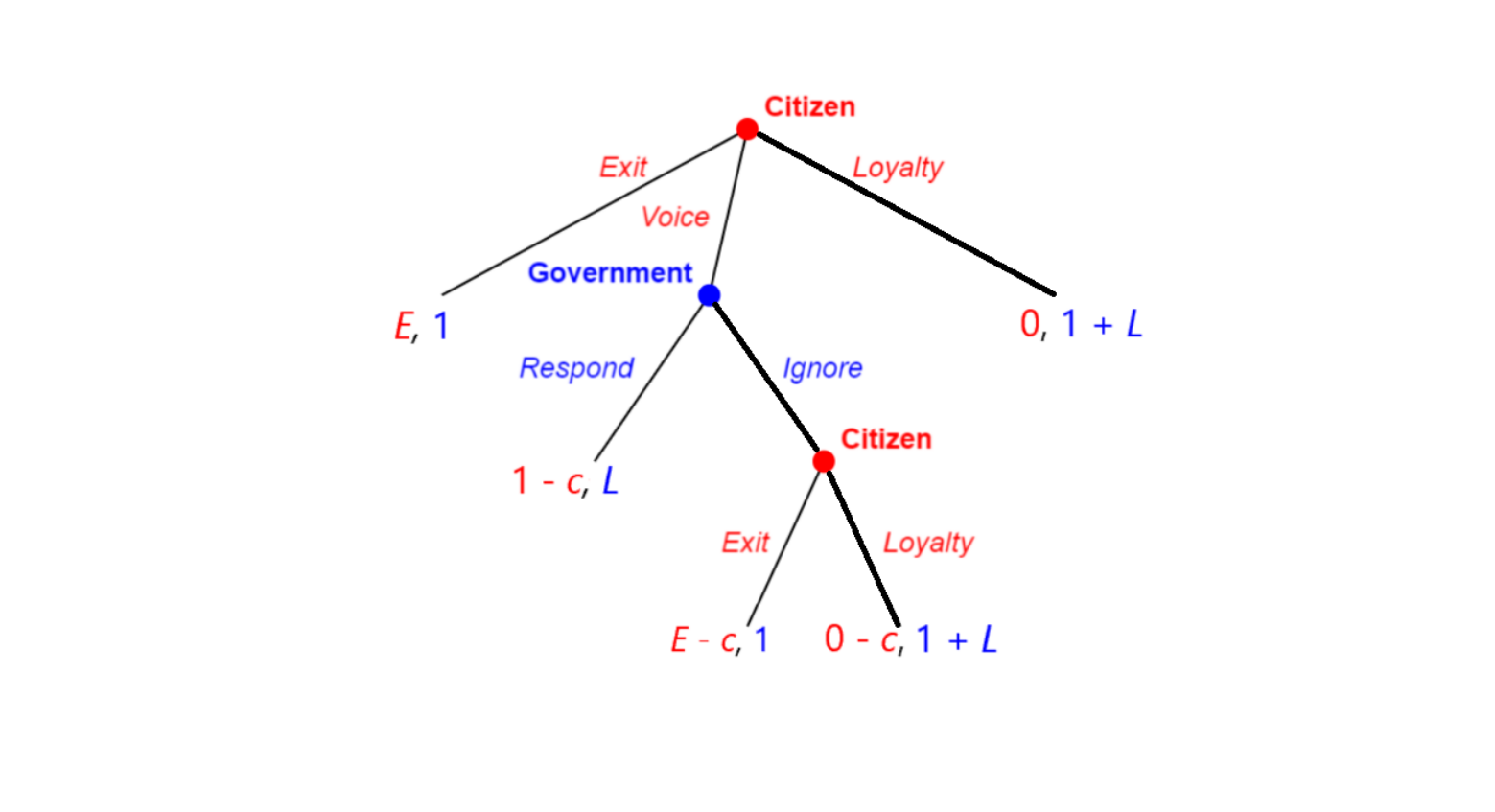

Citizen
Exit
Voice
Loyalty
Government
E, 1
0, 1 + L
Respond
Ignore
Citizen
1 - c, L
Exit
Loyalty
E - c, 1
0 - c, 1 + L

Scenario 1: $E > 0; L > 1$



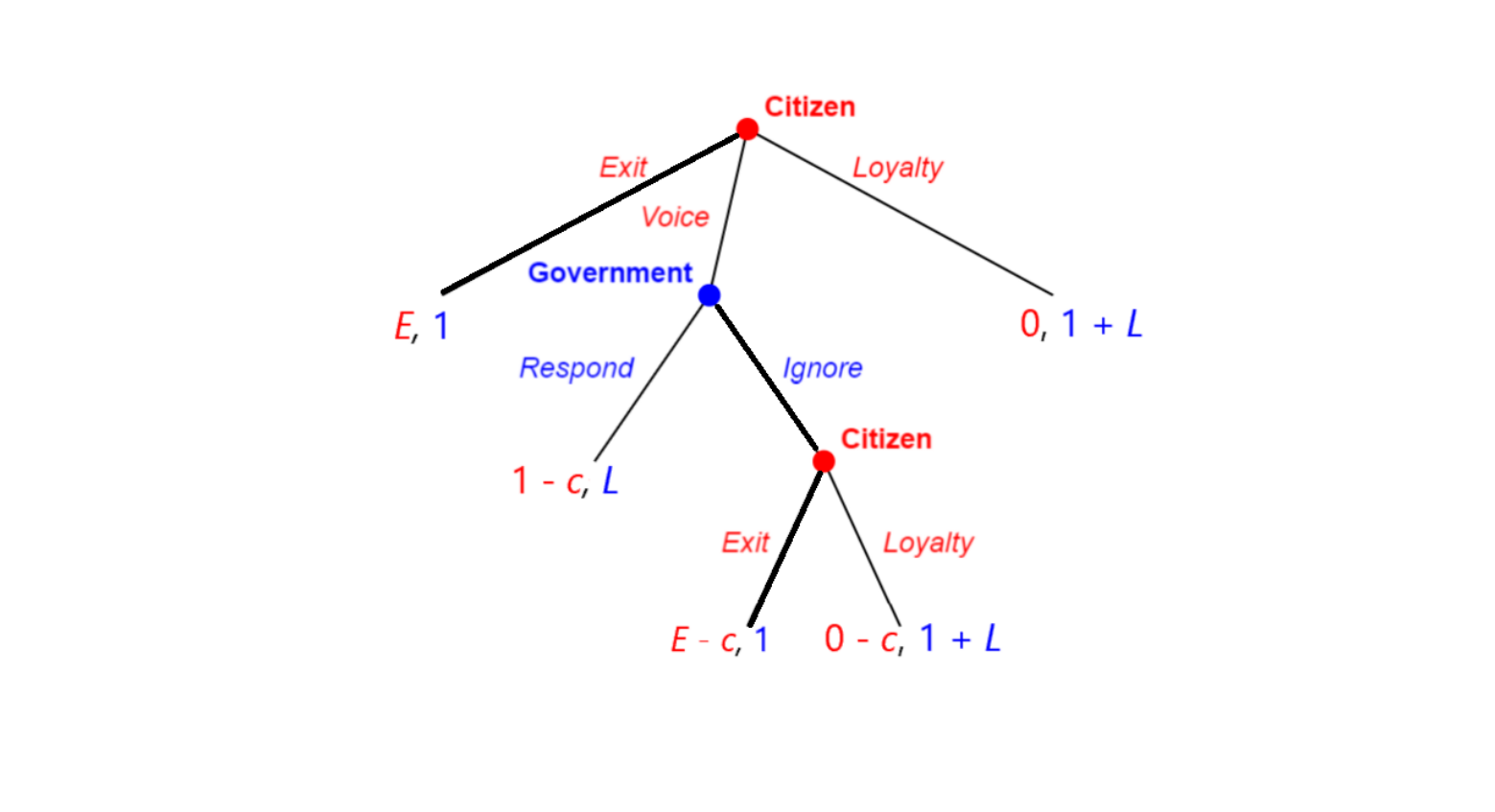
- **Equilibrium:** (Voice, Exit; Respond)

Scenario 2: $E < 0; L > 1$



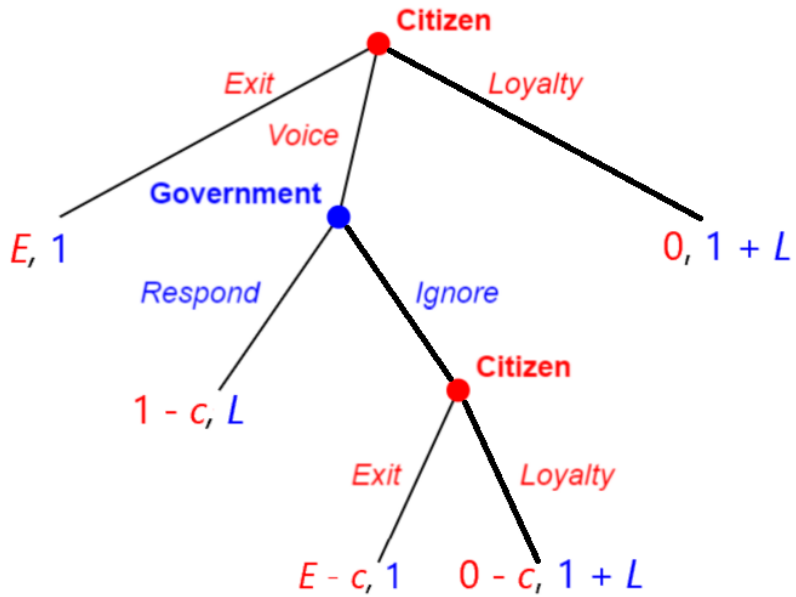
- **Equilibrium:** (Loyalty, Loyalty; Ignore)

Scenario 3: $E > 0; L < 1$



- **Equilibrium:** (Exit, Exit; Ignore)

Scenario 4: $E < 0; L < 1$



- **Equilibrium:** (Loyalty, Loyalty; Ignore)

Summary

Scenario	Values	Outcome
1	$E > 0; L > 1$	(Voice, Exit; Respond)
2	$E < 0; L > 1$	(Loyalty, Loyalty; Ignore)
3	$E > 0; L < 1$	(Exit, Exit; Ignore)
4	$E < 0; L < 1$	(Loyalty, Loyalty; Ignore)

- Government responds only if:
  - Citizen has credible exit option $(E > 0)$ AND
  - Government depends on the citizen $(L > 1)$

Takeaways

- Politics is ubiquitous
- Not always helpful to analyze something from a political lens
- When it is, EVL is a useful model to understand political situations
- One of **many** models we can use to understand social and political phenomena in a productive way

Thursday:

What are States?

Tip: Focus on the examples of failed states